

Go East

Agent 001 scoures Singapore for the best deals in hardware

We've seen our Lamington Roads, Nehru Places and Manish Markets crammed with computer hardware, electronic gadgets, cheap deals and friendly dealers. Now imagine a place that has electronic and computer equipment stacked one on top of the other for six full floors!

Welcome to Sim Lim Square, a shopping mall on Rochar Canal Road, Singapore, which enjoys the rather overburdening reputation of being the Mecca for computer hardware and electronic gadgets in South East Asia. The entire gamut of gadgetry is here: PCs, peripherals, HiFi Audio/Video, DVDs, cell phones, software, etc.

So how does it compare with the *desi* hotbeds of hardware? For one, you can buy the absolute latest in computer hardware. No waiting lists—if it's released, it's here! I found the Intel Pentium 4 2.4 GHz, Athlon XP 2100+ and 120 GB hard drives along with top-of-the-line GeForce4s, Xboxes, PS2s and other droolable hardware! Add to that the dozens of small vendors clamouring for your attention and you know you'll get the best deals. Unlike most Indian dealers, these guys won't take you for a ride and have intimate knowledge about the products, their releases and revisions. So even if you aren't tech-savvy, they will help you make the right choice. They are also aware of

problem products and advise against buying particular products if they've had higher than average return rates.

Fourth floor ho!

The fourth floor mainly deals with computer equipment and that's where I spent most of my time. Almost everything is cheaper here. From motherboards to hard drives to memory to processors, you'll end up saving a bundle on almost every PC component. You can buy an IBM Deskstar 120GXP 40 GB 7,200-rpm drive for as low as S\$150 (approx Rs 4,000), 40x CD-Writers are available for around



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benlar

Rs 4,000, and a 512 MB stick of DDR memory is available for just Rs 7,000. Compare this to the 10,000 bucks you would have to shell out for the same amount of memory in India and you'll soon be singing my tune.

Even I was amazed at some of the things that I managed to find: a 256 MB module of the Corsair XMS3000, the world's fastest memory, running at a whopping 370 MHz! It was available for S\$265 (approx Rs 7,000). Also for sale were the newly released GeForce4 Ti4600 video cards. These were being sold for around Rs 20,000. These cards aren't available in India yet and when launched will cost nothing less than Rs 35,000. I even found some exotic cooling solutions



■ Buying mobile phones is generally not recommended because of negligible price differences.

■ When you buy computer hardware, ensure that it works. Some shops allow you to test the parts, while others refuse to even let you open the package.

■ Every thing that you purchase from Singapore will be taxable at 3 per cent GST (Goods and Services Tax). This can be refunded if you spend above a particular value in the same store. Refunds can be collected at the airport, so be sure to get proper bills made at the time of purchase.

■ Check the prices online at www.hardwarezone.com, www.vr-zone.com, and also look around at other stores before making a purchase decision.

■ Bargaining of about S\$10-15 is permissible.

■ Most of the electronics are rated at 220 volts, 50 Hz. Double check before making a purchase.

■ Refrain from buying fragile items like hard drives due to the high risk involved while transporting them back home.

like the Cooler Master HHC-001, all copper heat sinks and various water-cooling kits—pretty handy if you're the over-clocking type.

But the highlight turned out to be the specially designed combos of motherboards, processors and RAM that guarantee huge savings—sometimes up to 20 per cent on the original MRP. You can get a Pentium 4 1.6A and ASUS P4B266-C combination for S\$490 (approx Rs 13,000). This bundle alone saves you over 25 per cent on the Indian pricing, which would come to around Rs 17,000. On the AMD front, an Athlon XP 2000+ along with the feature-packed MSI KT3Ultra ARU board (based on the KT333 chipset) was selling for S\$545 (approx Rs 15,000)!

To buy or not to buy

So should we all run to Singapore to fulfill our computing needs? Not really. Whether the trip is really worth it will depend on the current exchange rate and the amount of custom duty you'd end up paying. There is also the significant risk of no warranty and after-sales service. Remember that you'll have to bear all shipping costs to Singapore and back in case something goes wrong. ☞



Game Treat

Dreaming of playing high-end 3D games on a low budget? You can now purchase a Pine Excalibur

GeForce2 MX 400 64MB DDR card for just Rs 3,650! Go frag some!